

FRANCE



THE LARGEST COUNTRY in western Europe, France stretches from the Pyrenees in the south to the English Channel in the north. A founder member of the European Economic Community (now European Union), France plays a key role in world affairs. It is a leading industrial nation, although some five per cent of the population works in farming. The first of the modern republics, France includes Corsica, Guyana, and various islands in the Caribbean and Pacific Ocean.

FRANCE FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Paris
AREA	551,500 sq km (212,930 sq miles)
POPULATION	57,800,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	French
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Euro
LIFE EXPECTANCY	78 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	333
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	99%

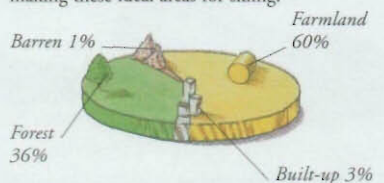
Physical features

France's landscape varies from undulating fields in the north to sparse hills in the Massif Central, and mountains in the Alps and Pyrenees in the south.

Corsica

With an area of 8,630 sq km (3,350 sq miles), Corsica is the third largest Mediterranean island. Fragrant, thorny scrub called *maquis* covers the slopes of towering granite peaks, and rich fertile valleys are used to graze sheep and grow vines. The capital is Ajaccio.

	39°C (102°F)	-17°C (1°F)
Climate		
Northwest France,	18°C (64°F)	3°C (37°F)
particularly Brittany, is mild but damp. The east has hot summers and stormy winters. Summers in the south are dry and hot, and forest fires are common. In the Pyrenees and Alps, winter snowfalls are heavy, making these ideal areas for skiing.		
	584 mm (23 in)	



Land use

France's fertile farmland includes gently rolling pastures and fields of wheat and sugar beet in the north, and vineyards and lavender fields in the south. Much of the Massif Central is pasture land for grazing sheep.

Paris

The Louvre Museum lies on the fashionable Right Bank of the River Seine, which divides the city. The Left Bank is traditionally home to students, artists, and the famous Eiffel Tower. One of the world's most beautiful and most visited capitals, Paris is the cultural and political centre of France.

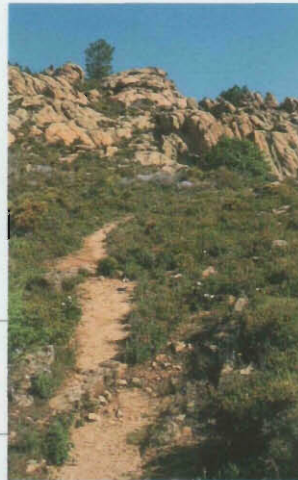


The Louvre Museum

River Seine

From its source in the east, the River Seine crosses Paris, before winding its way north to the Atlantic Ocean. France's river network, which also includes the Loire and the Rhône, is used for transport and for irrigating farmland.

The Seine in Normandy



Corsican maquis

